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UNDERCOVER TALK

From dialect prep to crime-thriller obsessions, the *Kartavya* cast reflects on storytelling and craft **P5**

(Clockwise from below) Stills from the production of the second season of *Tucci in Italy*; and Stanley Tucci and Meryl Streep in *The Devil Wears Prada 2*. NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



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Stanley Tucci is delighting fans on the big screen as the stylish Nigel in *The Devil Wears Prada 2*. He also returns to the small screen with Season 2 of his food-and-travel show, *Tucci in Italy* that launched Friday on Nat Geo.

Like Season 1, the follow-up to the Emmy Award-winning (Outstanding Hosted Nonfiction Series or Special), *Stanley Tucci: Searching for Italy*, *Tucci in Italy* sees the American actor-director visit five regions in Italy – Naples and Campania, Sicily, Le Marche, Sardinia, and Veneto (where he weighs in on the origins of tiramisu!).

Tucci, who made his acting debut in the black comedy *Prizzi's Honor* (1985) went on to act in several films and franchises, including *The Hunger Games* where he plays the blue-haired master of ceremonies Caesar Flickerman (a character Tucci has joked resembles tiramisu) and as the serial killer George Harvey in Peter Jackson's *Lovely Bones* (2009) for which he was nominated for an Academy Award.

More recently, he played Cardinal Bellini in Edward Berger's *Conclave*. He has also directed films such as *Big Night* and *Joe Gould's Secret*.

Apart from writing *The Tucci Cookbook*, *The Tucci Table: Cooking With Family and Friends*, *Taste: My Life Through Food*, and *What I Ate in One Year*, and hosting a food-and-travel series, Tucci has worked extensively on the small screen as well. He received an Emmy nomination for his role as Jack L Warner in *Feud* and appeared as Bernard Orlick in the spy thriller *Citadel*, starring Richard Madden and Priyanka Chopra Jonas.

Family first
The 65-year-old actor sees a similarity between India and Italy in the fondness for food

As *Tucci in Italy* returns for its second season, Stanley Tucci reflects on dialects, dining tables, dark histories, and why the best stories are never scripted

and family. “I’ve never been to India, but from everything I’ve heard, there are similarities, from the importance of family to the importance of sharing food, and the diverse dialects and traditions throughout the country,” Tucci says over a video call from New York. “India is a huge country,” Tucci hastens to add, “while Italy is only about 60 million people. Italians eat together, maybe more than any other culture. They certainly eat together a lot more than the Americans or the British.”

Tucci, who is married to his *The Devil Wears Prada* co-star Emily Blunt’s sister, Felicity, adds, “The British will come together on a Sunday for a



roast, but the majority of people in Britain do not sit down to dinner all the time, because both parents are working, or for whatever reason. After the Second World War, that started to

become the norm in so many countries.”

A time to decompress
Italy, Tucci says, has maintained the tradition of eating together, although it is starting to fade. “It’s absolutely important because it’s a time to decompress. It’s a time to interact with one another, even if that interaction might be people having an argument over the table, at least you’re interacting,” he says, laughing gently. “It gives you time to



Italian fork lore



Nigel's return

Nigel Kipling, *Runway's* creative director, has forgiven Meryl Streep's Miranda Priestly for nixing his chances to fly solo in Paris 20 years ago — as he tells Anne Hathaway's Andy in *The Devil Wears Prada 2*. Returning to Nigel, Tucci says it definitely felt like, “meeting an old friend”. When asked to pick a favourite costume from the movie, which features designers including Dries Van Noten (Miranda's tassel jacket), Sa Su Phi (Miranda's grey blazer and skirt), Christian Dior (Emily's structured shirt), Jean Paul Gaultier (Andy's pinstripe suit), Gabriela Hearst (Andy's maxi dress) and Balenciaga (Miranda's red gown), Tucci said laughing, “I loved every one of them.”



connect with one another, and separates you from the daily grind. It's a nice way to commune with people you love.”

Getting comfortable
This season, Tucci says is a more personal journey. “Every time you go, you’re discovering more and more. Over the years, I’ve become more comfortable doing the show. Sometimes revisiting places has an emotional effect on you because you’re drawn to places that make you feel happy.”

Sardinia forever
The series draws a clear line between landscape, history, and the food on the plate. While saying that no one region stood out above the others, Sardinia holds a special place in Tucci's heart. “It is interesting because it's almost like a different world, not even a different country. It feels and is older than old. There are all these eons and myths and ancient sagas of Sardinian culture that go back thousands of years. There were people living there 7,000 years ago, that's pretty amazing. There's a lot to unpack there.” Le Marche and Sardinia also required a different kind of listening, Tucci says. “Everywhere you go in Italy, the dialects are so distinctly different that even if you speak some Italian, like I do, you can be hard-pressed to understand what people are saying. There's a depth to Sardinia that you could keep digging into forever, discovering more and more things. It's so interesting to

me. Even the mafia had a difficult time trying to get a foothold in Sardinia, because they are incredibly tough people.”

Though Naples and Sicily carry heavy histories alongside exuberant food cultures, Tucci does not see the regions as different from any other part of Italy. “Every country and every part of Italy has a dark history.”

Learning to listen
Stepping back and letting other people tell their stories took some getting used to for Tucci.

“I had to learn how to do it. I was nervous when I first started doing this about six, seven years ago. Once you do it, you just know it's the right thing to do. They're the ones who have to tell the story. I'm just the conduit.”

Talking about the production, Tucci says, “A lot of times you get a producer who might say, ‘Ask for this,’ or, ‘Have her say that again,’ and it doesn't work. There are certain bullet points we want to hit in an interview, but I need to let the person keep talking until they get there. They're not performers. They might be nervous in front of the camera, so you have to be aware of that.”

Language matters
A lot of times, Tucci says, the producers might say, “‘Why do they have to speak in Italian?’ Because they're Italian, that's why,” he laughs. “Even though they say they can speak English, they can't really speak English, and they'll be uncomfortable, and we'll be here for days, and then they won't be happy, and we won't get the story we want. So then let them talk in Italian, and that's it.” The takeaway from the series Tucci hopes for is for people to see how culturally diverse and complex Italy is. “There's no such thing as an Italian.”

Tucci in Italy streams on JioHotstar, with Season 2 episodes airing every Friday at 7pm on Nat Geo





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pick of the week



Sliver of silver

Bidriware, a 14th-Century handicraft from Bidar, Karnataka, that involves inlaying pure silver, brass, or gold into a permanently blackened zinc-copper alloy, takes centrestage in MiRooh's new collection Nakkashi. Its black velvet table runners, placemats and cushion covers feature motifs of flora and fauna in antique silver zari embroidery.

Shop the collection, starting at ₹1,899 on the soft-furnishing brand's website, mirooh.in.



Style file

India's top make-up artists, including Australia-born Daniel Bauer and Namrata Soni, will be at Phoenix MarketCity Chennai's first-ever beauty and lifestyle festival, The Beauty Experience, on May 16 and 17, 5pm onwards. Expect a fashion-meets-beauty showcase inspired by stylist Prasad Bidapa and a lipstick installation at the mall. Tickets for masterclass by Daniel and Namrata start at ₹299 on in.bookmyshow.com.



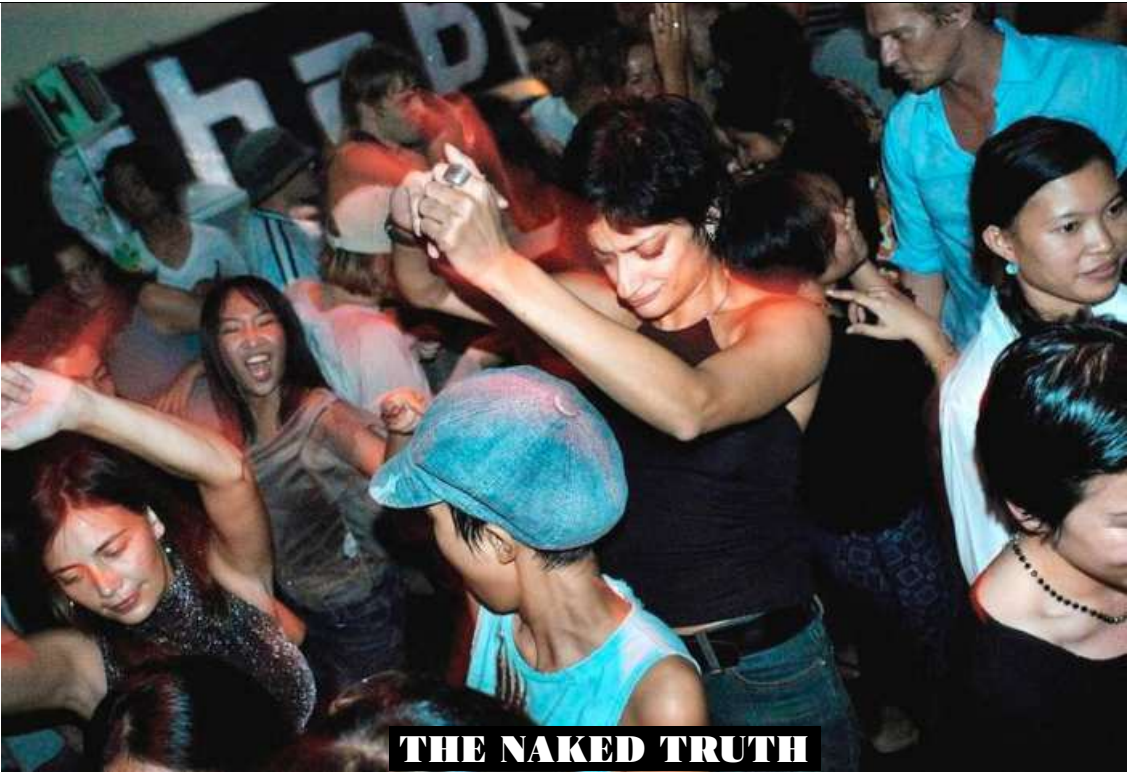
Music meets art

Chennai-based Naad Milan Foundation, where art, music and wellness converge, will co-host The Art of Sukoon, with Makery, a weekly art club in Chennai. At the workshop, artist Srividya Sriram will guide participants through simple art exercises while musician Akshaya Murali will strum the guitar to the poetry of Sufi saint Kabir. On May 22, from 6.30pm, at Sahana's, Abhiramapuram. Registrations start at ₹500 via [@artclubmakery](https://www.instagram.com/artclubmakery) and [@naadmilanfoundation](https://www.instagram.com/naadmilanfoundation).



Feast for the eyes

Continuum Circle presents Between Becoming & Being, a group exhibition by young artists from the Government College of Fine Arts, Chennai. Through painting, printmaking, sculpture and mixed media, the show reflects on memory, identity, body, ecology and everyday existence. Featuring Deepika, Ganesh S, Jagath Ravi, Padmapriya K, and others, the exhibition is on at Lalit Kala Akademi, Greams Road, till May 21, from 11am to 7pm. Entry is free.



THE NAKED TRUTH

(Left) Party goes at a Bangkok club; and a couple relaxing on lounge chairs by a swimming pool. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK



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Geosexual isn't exactly a new term, though it has recently gained fresh currency online after singer Kesha joked that she's now "mostly celibate" except when she's in Italy. Technically, however, the term's origin has a far less glamorous story. According to the National Institutes of Health, geosexual was initially used in public health research to map how geography and movement patterns influence sexual behaviour and STI transmission, particularly among men who have sex with men. Researchers even categorised people into "geosexual archetypes" based on where they met partners and had sex.

Though clinically significant, the word's interpretation on the Internet has evolved into a shorthand for people whose romantic or sexual personalities seem to change entirely once they leave their hometown. A 2026 survey by Indian dating app QuackQuack, conducted on 10,853 users aged 20 to 35 across metros, suburbs, and rural towns, found that 33% of Gen Z daters were actively avoiding

Pincode for desire

From Goa to Pattaya, young Indians are increasingly discovering that intimacy feels easier when nobody knows their surname, salary, or family WhatsApp dynamics

romantic escalation altogether, embracing what the app called "romantic fasting". And yet, travel seems to short-circuit that caution. Because the minute people leave the cities where they work, network, answer family calls, and constantly optimise their reputation, the stakes feel lower. Even desire stops feeling like something that needs to be managed correctly. According to a Mumbai-based marketing professional, who admits to having had his fair share of encounters in Bangkok and Pattaya, "There are repercussions to blurring personal and professional boundaries in the city where one lives." This feels particularly true in cities where work, dating, friendship circles, gym memberships, exes, and family networks all are connected with each other. Another Delhi-based young traveller I spoke to said he doesn't necessarily engage in

anything hectic when he travels, like kink or group play, but he does tend to let his guard down. "My inhibitions with group settings specifically are a lot freer when I'm travelling. I find myself going with the flow a lot more than I do here. While I normally struggle with communicating interests and wants, that isn't an issue at all while I'm somewhere far away. There's just a way higher degree of confidence. To say hello, to ask for a dance, or to ask salacious questions." And perhaps that confidence comes from temporarily escaping the architecture of everyday identity. "I think we all travel to escape versions of ourselves, whether we're conscious of it or not," he added. "I also think we're a little more primed for curiosity when we're travelling. There's so much more to fantasise about and read into people you come across."

Finding freedom
A Goa-based friend, who opened up her relationship a few years ago, told me something similar. "We met couples from places like villages in Himachal, from tiny towns you'd never expect," she said. "They were shy, but honestly kind of cute about it. They told us they can't even think of meeting people where

they live. And they can't afford travelling to bigger cities regularly just to explore or meet like-minded people." So most of their intimacy, she explained, existed digitally. "A lot of it was exhibitionism online, flirting online, roleplay online. But they planned a week-long trip to Goa specifically so they could finally meet real people and indulge a little without fear." Which perhaps says more about India's relationship with desire than any formal study could. Outside major metros, privacy itself can feel like a luxury. Smaller towns often come with tighter community structures, stronger moral policing, less anonymity, and fewer spaces where people can safely experiment with identity or sexuality without social fallout. And Goa, interestingly, keeps resurfacing in these conversations. A place where people can step outside inherited versions of themselves. Not permanently, of course. Just long enough to loosen the grip of scrutiny and make one or two decisions that absolutely cannot be discussed in the family WhatsApp group.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum

Get in the taxi, Chennai

Travelling pop-up Pilitaxi makes its Chennai debut with 22 craft-led brands from across India



(Left) A still from Pilitaxi's recent pop-up in Hyderabad; and a model sporting artisanal jewellery by Baala Jewels which will be showcased at Pilitaxi's pop-up in Chennai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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To curate Pilitaxi's first-ever pop-up in Chennai, its founder Bijaya Dutta, who describes the travelling exhibition platform as a stage for homegrown, artisanal and independent brands rooted in heritage techniques, kept the coastal city's climate in mind. The idea, she says, was to rope in brands featuring breathable fabrics, artisanal jewellery and handcrafted footwear. "Chennai has a strong appreciation for textiles, craftsmanship, and conscious fashion, making it a meaningful market for us," she says. With a total of 22 brands in tow, the pop-up aims to introduce the city to labels like Beige, O Layla, Winglore, Slomotion, Atouri, Woolknitters and Bahi. On their maiden outing at The Folly, Amethyst, these brands offer not just exclusivity but also distinct craft narratives. Bijaya explains: "For instance, each Atouri garment is created at a slow pace by weavers in Bengal. Designs range from checks and handblock prints to hand embroidery. The textiles include handspun and handwoven cotton mul and

linen sourced from different regions in India. Similarly, Beige uses pure fabrics and reinterprets different art forms through hand-drawn patterns. Also, Woolknitters, from Himachal, celebrates traditional Kullu craftsmanship through woven wool shawls inspired by mountain life, alongside charming hand-crocheted creations like the *jujurana* bird." Born in Kolkata in 2000, Pilitaxi has hosted 63 retrospectives across nine cities, including Kolkata, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Kochi, Pune, Delhi, Gurugram and Ahmedabad. "Chennai will be our 10th stop and 64th chapter," Bijaya informs. Of Pilitaxi's financial model, she says, "We do not work on a profit-sharing basis; instead, we charge a very nominal participation fee." Of the many offerings at the pop-up, Bijaya highlights two sari brands – Bunavat and Threads Per Inch. "We also have an artisanal leather footwear brand Slomotion, which will certainly appeal to the cityfolk," Bijaya signs off.

Pop-up by Pilitaxi will be hosted at The Folly, Amethyst, on May 16 and 17. Products start at ₹500.



Snapshots from Pune's Izipizi Street — buzzing with flavour, colour, and urban energy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Pune takes it easy!

Izipizi Street exists in that place where flavour and aroma meet drama and a healthy amount of urban mischief

Siddharth Dasgupta

Have you even experienced Bangkok, Hanoi, or Hong Kong if you have not sat by the side of the road, on a rickety plastic chair, and dug into wickedly aromatic bowls of noodles, broths, and dim sum? I am feeling a distinct sense of Asian culinary déjà vu, far removed from the chaotic street markets of Southeast Asia, in the heart of Pune's Kalyani Nagar. Its Izipizi Street hits you with its concept before it seduces you with its food. Individual hawker carts sell distinct staples of the Asian food like dim sum. Overhead, red lanterns sway lazily in the magic of a Pune breeze. Red plastic chairs and mahjong tables lie strewn in spacious seating

islands, where bubble tea and matcha accompany impromptu flirtation. The indoor section is as much a homage to the street food market environment – rattan and worn iron chairs, an open bar, hawker carts for sushi robata grills, and a communal *chabudai* that seats approximately 14. But all the conceptual glory would fall on its face if the food were not up to the mark. The opening salvo of the Shio Koji Fried Chicken puts those fears to rest. This is rendered izakaya-style deep-fried chicken with a strong umami accent courtesy of the fermented Japanese seasoning. Skewers of lush yakitori sing on the backs of a sharp teriyaki glaze and flavoured chilli oil. "The food and the experience here are born from our travels through Asia, our passion for bringing those authentic urban flavours and that



street spirit to this city," says chef-partner Hanoze Shroff, referring to himself and the other partners at Together Hospitality, Vijeta Singh and Karan Khilnani. The food falters slightly in places, as with the far-too-greasy curry leaf calamari or hot garlic chicken dim sum whose notes of garlic are overpowered by the Sichuan chilli oil. For the most part though, the menu rises above the ordinary in Hanoze's deft hands. Tangra pork chilli pays accurate homage to Kolkata's Chinese-style spare ribs and belly, and char kway teow is an earthy, rustic standout. Coming from the people

behind the heavily awarded Cobbler & Crew, Elephant & Co, Gather, and Juju, Izipizi Street has big steps to follow. Kitschy stickers pop out at unexpected places, but nothing appears jarring. Partner Vijeta's branding firm Rare Ideas ought to take a bow for the vibe. More than being cuisine or region-specific, Izipizi Street is a mood-specific address. You head to moto moto sushi for spicy tuna, avocado, togarashi, tenkasu, and jalapeño salsa crunch bomb that is Itachi. Mixologist Arijit Bose's unfussy, ingredient-driven drinks programme, overseen by Sarthak Bisht, presents Skyy vodka, lychee, passion fruit, and kaffir lime rejuvenation of a 'Juicy'. Chances are, you will end things off at Izipizi Street's glass-walled, fishbowl-like karaoke room – a 20-person marvel of kitsch and colour that also serves as a private dining room. Amid awful singing and much laughter, you will realise that togetherness is a core ethic at Izipizi Street. 'Kindness wins' lies scrawled across the main menu. Here at Izipizi Street, intimacy and flavour win as well.

Saif Ali Khan, Rasika Dugal and Manish Chaudhari open up about crime-thriller tropes, dialects, and Amitabh Bachchan’s advice for their now-streaming film *Kartavya*

Telling stories with intent

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Saif Ali Khan chooses to don an all-black outfit on a summer afternoon as we sit down at the Netflix office in Mumbai for an interaction on his upcoming film, *Kartavya*. Making some inside jokes with his co-actors, Rasika Dugal and Manish Chaudhari, Saif takes a chair, while tossing around chirpy one-liners. He plays a cop in the upcoming film, completing a circle with Netflix as the streamer kickstarted in India with Saif donning the uniform in *Sacred Games*. The actor was excited by the international appeal of the platform when he was approached to play Inspector Sartaj Singh in the 2018 show.

“They had just made *Narcos* and the concept of doing a mafia show in your own language for an international audience was just enticing,” says Saif, as he mentions a scene in the series which involved finding a piece of paper in a cabinet holding three thousand files. “I hadn’t seen something like it in a normal commercial film. Its treatment was unique especially how Bombay was shot with the back streets full of rats, sewers and chaos.”

A gritty crime-drama, *Sacred Games* also defined the aesthetics of streaming in India. The genre itself is still popular on OTT, giving way to some tropes that have stayed along,



most of them inspired by movies that came before. Like the thinking detective, sitting below a light with a cigarette in hand, which Saif finds interesting to watch in a crime-thriller. “I also like watching crime scenes where the cops are talking about other personal things while examining dead bodies. I have seen that in some films and would love to do a scene like that,” he says. Rasika finds red herrings fun to watch. “I like when something misleads you and you go on a trail and that is not the trail,” she says, as Manish pitches in, “I love those scenes where there’s a sound outside the door in the middle of the night. And you move towards the door with a gun and open it just



slightly to check. I actually got to play that in *Powder* (2010).” Manish plays a cop as well in *Kartavya*, helmed by Pulkit, known for directing the Bhumi Pednekar starrer, *Bhakshak* (2024). The filmmaker had initially offered the role of the antagonist in *Bhakshak* to Manish, who was hesitant to get into the darker shades of the character. “He does some horrible things in the film. I told Pulkit, ‘I am sorry, I have children’. So, he came back to me for *Kartavya* and said, ‘Now you can’t say no’. I was happy to do it this time,” Manish smiles. Rasika was intrigued with the story as well as the way in which the screenplay was written entirely in Devanagari. “It read like a short

story from the progressive writers movement. I was amused by that. I often ask for scripts which have dialogue in Devanagari because I want to read it in the language that it will be spoken in. It gets difficult to read Hindi in Roman script as you start talking like that,” adds Rasika.

Learning Devanagari
Jokes aside, Saif says that he too can read in Devanagari. “I have learned it over the years and it is great to read like that. Its sad that many people don’t know it still,” he says. In *Kartavya*, the actor seems to be catching on

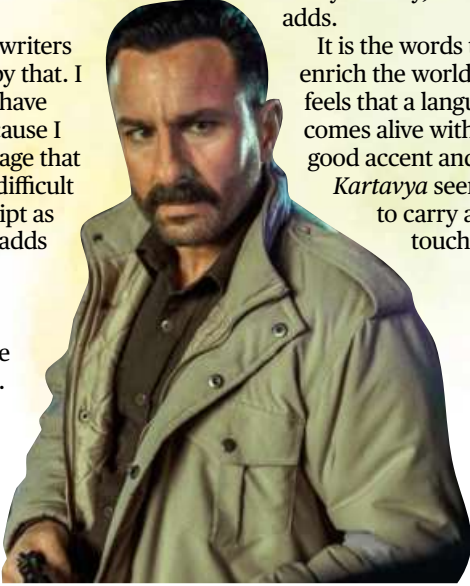
(Clockwise from left) Saif Ali Khan; with Rasika Dugal; and with Manish Chaudhari in *Kartavya*. NETFLIX AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



to the dialect of the heartland quite fluently, sparking memories of Langda Tyagi from *Omkara* (2006). “In my head the dialect in *Kartavya* felt similar to *Omkara*. The process of mastering an accent is like learning a song as you have to work on each word. So, it becomes easier when you do it repetitively,” he says, while also adding how he has learnt about accents from his co-actors, like an advise he got from megastar Amitabh Bachchan, when they were working together.

“He asked me to practise dialogues all the time, on the treadmill, in the shower and then forget about them so that it becomes a part of you.” Saif also recalls another interesting tip he received from Deepak Dobriyal, with whom he worked in *Omkara*. “He told me to say the dialogues loudly first so that the guy in the other building can hear. This makes you confident with the line and then you can say it softly,” he adds.

It is the words that enrich the world. Saif feels that a language comes alive with a good accent and *Kartavya* seems to carry a touch of



that earthen sentiment. However, despite rooting the story and performances in on-ground realities, a sense of stagnancy has prevailed on streaming where there’s little reinvention of genre tropes along with rising discussions of algorithms guiding what stories get told and depleting attention spans determining storytelling decisions. Rasika feels that these changes take place due to technological advancements. “When streaming services came, web-shows were looked down upon. It was considered to be a thing that people who were largely unemployed in Versova would do. But now that perception has shifted. So, these changes are bound to happen and people will deal with them creatively.”

Manish adds that there is need for diverse stories to be told. “We grew up watching Clint Eastwood in the West and Amitabh Bachchan and Dharamendra here. All of them were part of some great stories. We never thought of the separation of commercial cinema or artistic cinema. For a young person like me, I wanted to be part of both these worlds. So, it is important to tell great stories with intent,” he says.

Saif addresses the current landscape and says, “You keep hearing people telling you not to do something or make stories which someone watching on phone should follow. You hear all this and then comes a big movie which defies all the laws and all the rules go out of the window. So, once in a while, we need a director to make a proper piece of cinema and not content.”

Kartavya streams on Netflix .

Viren Naidu

Last year, Australia cancelled his visa. Last month, the UK blocked his entry. On May 23, India will throw open the gates of Delhi’s Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium for him.

When American rapper and songwriter Kanye West, now legally changed to Ye, was announced as a headliner for London’s annual rap and hip-hop music festival Wireless this March, the backlash reached 10 Downing Street. Prime Minister Sir Keir Starmer called his invitation “deeply concerning”. Within days, West’s Electronic Travel Authorisation was revoked, with the Home Office declaring his presence as “not conducive to the public good”. Pepsi and Diageo withdrew sponsorship. The festival was called off.

In July of last year, Australia refused West entry after the release of his heavily panned song ‘Heil Hitler’, timed to coincide with the 80th anniversary of Nazi Germany’s defeat.

West’s most infamous public disruption – where he stormed on stage during Taylor Swift’s acceptance speech at the 2009 MTV Awards to give Beyonce a shoutout – seems like a distant memory. But it pales in comparison to provocations that followed: calling slavery a “choice” and selling swastika branded T-shirts online.

Even before the Wireless fallout, the mayor of Marseille, concerned that he would use his stage to promote Nazism during his upcoming concert, said he was “not welcome”.

Yet, on May 23, West will make his India debut in front of thousands in New Delhi. If parts of western democracies are silencing his rhetoric, India is handing him a microphone.

No longer perceived as a pitstop between Asian or West Asia tours, India today enjoys an undisputed spot on the world tour map.

Concert economy evolves

“India is not a fly-over country anymore,” says Andre Timmins, co-founder, Wizcraft, one of the promoters and organisers bringing West to India. “It’s becoming a must-stop.”

However, in India’s live performance ecosystem, that notoriety is managed. “When getting performers to India, we are well-versed with controversy that precedes them and associated risks,” says Deepak Choudhary, founder and MD, Eva Live, which has previously brought Bryan Adams and Enrique Iglesias to India.

He adds that the promoters have a record of their artists’ reputational setbacks, scandals, and problematic comments. “The biggest fallout is always commercial, as sponsors and brands may opt out,” Choudhary says.

“The consumer knows what it wants. If they want to see Kanye West, they will come,” says Deepak. This paradox shapes the Indian concert economy.

Music journalist and co-founder of The Indian Music Charts Podcast, Amit Gurbaxani feels that on the whole, Indian audiences do not care. He cites the Backstreet Boys as an example: their lead vocalist Nick Carter has been embroiled in legal controversies, yet when the band performed in India in 2023, the market response outweighed the controversy. American DJ Diplo, despite facing similar charges, performed to a packed crowd at Goa’s Royal Enfield Motoverse festival in 2025.



Kanye’s India pivot

Cancelled by Australia, barred from the UK and dropped from Wireless Festival, Kanye West now heads to India for his debut in New Delhi. His arrival offers a window into the country’s booming concert economy where songs are tweaked, spontaneity is scripted and controversy is carefully managed

Rapper Kanye West performs onstage during the *Vultures 1* playback concert during Rolling Loud 2024 at Hollywood Park Grounds on March 14, 2024 in Inglewood. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Spectacle over controversy

This is what makes India uniquely positioned for international artistes: while controversy may hamper sponsorship, it rarely hinders public demand. The system does not bar controversial artistes. Instead it softens the impact of that controversy without compromising the spectacle.

“Before even the international act arrives in India, what they can say, wear, comment or even sing, is already communicated to them,” says Akshat Mudbidri, founder, Adventure Global Talent. “These days, we are given mandates by local Government authorities – no obscenity, no profanity, and must not challenge the current political standing of the country,” says Mudbidri.

Promoters say heightened scrutiny from human rights groups, women’s organisations and watchdogs ahead of a performer’s arrival often pushes organisers towards pre-emptive censorship to avoid backlash.

Choudhary recalls how Enrique Iglesias suggested inviting a female fan on stage for a flirtatious number, a familiar trope in his concerts abroad. Choudhary nixed the idea immediately. “The police could get involved; I told him. And promoters become accountable.”

In India, the concert economy monitors even spontaneity. “There have been times where my artiste had to tweak lyrics – no references to alcohol, drugs or physical

attributes of women,” says Mudbidri who manages Romanian singer-songwriter Akcent.

Even the wardrobe isn’t spared. For a show in Hyderabad, Akcent intentionally wore a kurta, simply because it coincided with Eid and it helped him resonate more with his crowd.To Gauri Aayeer, music label head and frequent concert goer, these visual representations matter, recalling how rapper Central Cee wore a Mahadev T-shirt at Rolling Loud Mumbai. “Audiences respond to it every single time,” she says.

. While attending Coldplay’s London concert, Aayeer says that the band’s support for Palestine was a recurring theme. “They even invited a Palestinian artiste to perform.” In India, the same artiste shifted his tone. He referenced British colonial history, waved the LGBTQ+ rainbow flag and read out a Hindu chant. “A political statement lands differently in the West than it does in India,” Aayeer says.

For Timmins, the decision to bring West to India is not about his politics, though it includes his public image and the global discourse around him. “But you have to look at the complete picture,” he says. He recalls bringing Michael Jackson to India in 1996. “He was arguably the most polarising figure at the time,” Timmins says. “But we focussed on his craft and the cultural bridge his presence could build.”

Kanye West may arrive in India amid significant backlash. But once the lights go up in Delhi, he will enter an ecosystem adept at translating, editing and softening controversy before it reaches the stage. Politics will be dialled down, lyrics tweaked and spontaneity supervised, filtered heavily through a cultural and legal lens.

And even if an accidental moment does slip through, there is always music filling the space to drown it out.

A week in Bali, experiencing melukat temple blessings, sacred caves, and river rituals amidst mindful luxury, revealed the island’s deeper philosophy of harmony



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“Diversity is like a rainbow; In Bali, the people blend in like the seven colours and don’t see them as borders,” says Roby, our guide, as we stand before a sacred shrine at Sayan, a village close to Ubud in Bali, Indonesia. A beautiful way to see the world, especially given the current times of turmoil.

Roby and his two fellow guides take us through the temple blessing or ‘melukat’, a purification ritual designed to cleanse the body, mind, and soul with holy water.

Aimed at warding off negative energy – a belief that forms the core of Balinese culture – I realise these blessings are a way to learn about the locals’ relationship with the energies around them.

Perhaps it is this blessing that brought us here on the eve of Nyepi, the Balinese day of silence. The days leading up to this see the Ogoh Ogoh, large handcrafted monsters that depict the negative forces or bhuta kala, paraded across Bali as an act of spiritual cleansing.

One such Ogoh Ogoh stands tall at the lobby of The Four Seasons in Jimbaran Bay overlooking the clear waters of the Indian Ocean. A few steps away is the resort temple where their in-house priest welcomes us with a ritual – chants followed by the sprinkling of holy water – to tap into our inner energies and ward off negativity.

With this perfect start to the Balinese way of life, a buggy ride though the cobbled stone paths leads me to one of the 147 beachfront villas (and nine private residences) where a guardian angel set in stone welcomes me. Safe under his watchful eye, the week spent at Bali – at The Four Seasons in Jimbaran Bay and its sister property at Sayan – involved understanding the Balinese way of life, culture, and spirituality.

For the wellness-focussed, there are massages with gemstone oils and singing bowls, one that uses traditional instruments for a spiritual cleansing, another that pays homage to Bali’s irrigation system (listed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site) with crystal-energised water, a ‘sacred’ air nap in a silk hammock at the Sayan property with wellness mentor Ibu Fera chanting along, and my personal favourite, a visit to the 9th Century Goa Gong Cave



At Jimbaran Bay...

The entire property has been designed like a Balinese village, with thatched-roof villas nestled among tropical gardens.

Each villa comprises a series of pavilions within a courtyard enclosure that has a private plunge pool.

The resort features more than 300 palinggih, or Hindu shrines, reflecting Balinese culture, including one dating back to the 15th Century.

At Sayan...

This hillside sanctuary nestled along the sacred Ayung River features 60 rooms: 42 villas, and 18 suites.

At Riverside, their Mediterranean restaurant, savour dishes from Italy, Spain, France, Lebanon and Greece; and dishes from across the Indonesian archipelago are the highlight at Ayung terrace, the open-air treetop dining space.

Alongside river-inspired spa treatments, guests can experience a sacred water ceremony that harnesses Bali’s revered water element. It comprises a monsoon shower inspired by the UNESCO-listed subak system.



Temple guided by Ibu Atik, cultural ambassador at the Jimbaran Bay property.

For the journey’s second leg, we arrive in Sayan after a two-hour ride afloat the Ayung River, courtesy of a rafting adventure. The property’s design is an ode to Ubud’s rice paddy fields with the structure depicting a suspended rice bowl, and the resort comprises 18 suites and 42 villas that come with

outdoor seating.

Keeping with their philosophy of ‘slow’, we are taken on village tours and temple visits as part of the Can You Keep A Secret Tour, and no points for guessing: you will not find these spots on Instagram and thank God for that.

Over a seven-course dinner at their restaurant Sokasi’s (meaning basket in Balinese) open kitchen, Tim Churchmack, the

resort manager at Sayan, tells me keeping the property attuned to the region’s local culture has been key.

Be it the nomenclature and design of Sokasi to represent a woven basket or curating lived experiences like ‘A day in the life of a Balinese farmer.

Long after the magic of these meals, the serene villas, and memories of the

hospitality fade, it is the serenity of Bali that stays with you.

The meditative chants, breathwork to sync with the flowing river, and the belief that balancing the negative with the positive is what life is all about.

A souvenir worth cherishing.

The writer was in Bali at the invitation of Four Seasons



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Malayalam

An underwhelming affair



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Going by the number of crime thrillers and police procedurals set in the high ranges of Kerala, it would appear that our pristine hills are riddled with criminality and brutality. Debutant director Martin Joseph’s *Dridam* is also set in one such rural outpost in the hills, but the police station here is a rather peaceful place with no major criminal cases. When rookie cop Vijay (Shane Nigam) takes charge, he is taken in by the pleasant atmosphere in the neighbourhood. But soon it all changes for the worse with the recovery of a putrefied dead body, followed by robbery at a local bank. Calmness gives way to tension as Vijay and his colleagues come under immense pressure from the higher-ups as well as the public to solve the cases. Despite its laboured opening sequences, including a lengthy introduction scene involving Vijay and the other cops, this initial set up appeared promising enough.

Director Martin Joseph, a former assistant director of Jeethu Joseph, mostly sticks to the usual rhythm and turns we are used to seeing in police procedurals in recent years. At times, one gets the sense of a film progressing on autopilot. Even when there are some intriguing reveals at various points, much of it does not land with the desired impact. The writing by Linto Devasia and Jomon John, as well as the staging of the scenes, seems responsible in equal measure for this state of affairs.

All that quiet progress appears to have been aimed at taking the audience by surprise in the last act, which does have a very effective reveal, although some can sense it from miles ahead. But the effect is marred rather quickly when the film switches to an extreme violence mode. Even looking away from the screen might not be of help, for the sound of a sharp iron rod piercing into human flesh multiple times can be as sickening to listen to. It almost seems like a calculated assault targeting the current market for hyper violence, which the makers probably hoped would carry the film home. Not many are likely to fall for it.

Though Shane Nigam played a similar rookie cop in Priyadarshan’s *Corona Papers* (2023), he carries the role slightly differently here, radiating the vulnerability and hot-headedness of a newbie in a challenging position. The supporting cast, except Shobi Thilakan, has only a functional purpose.

Dridam has phases where it shows promise of becoming something. However, it only ends up becoming an underwhelming affair.

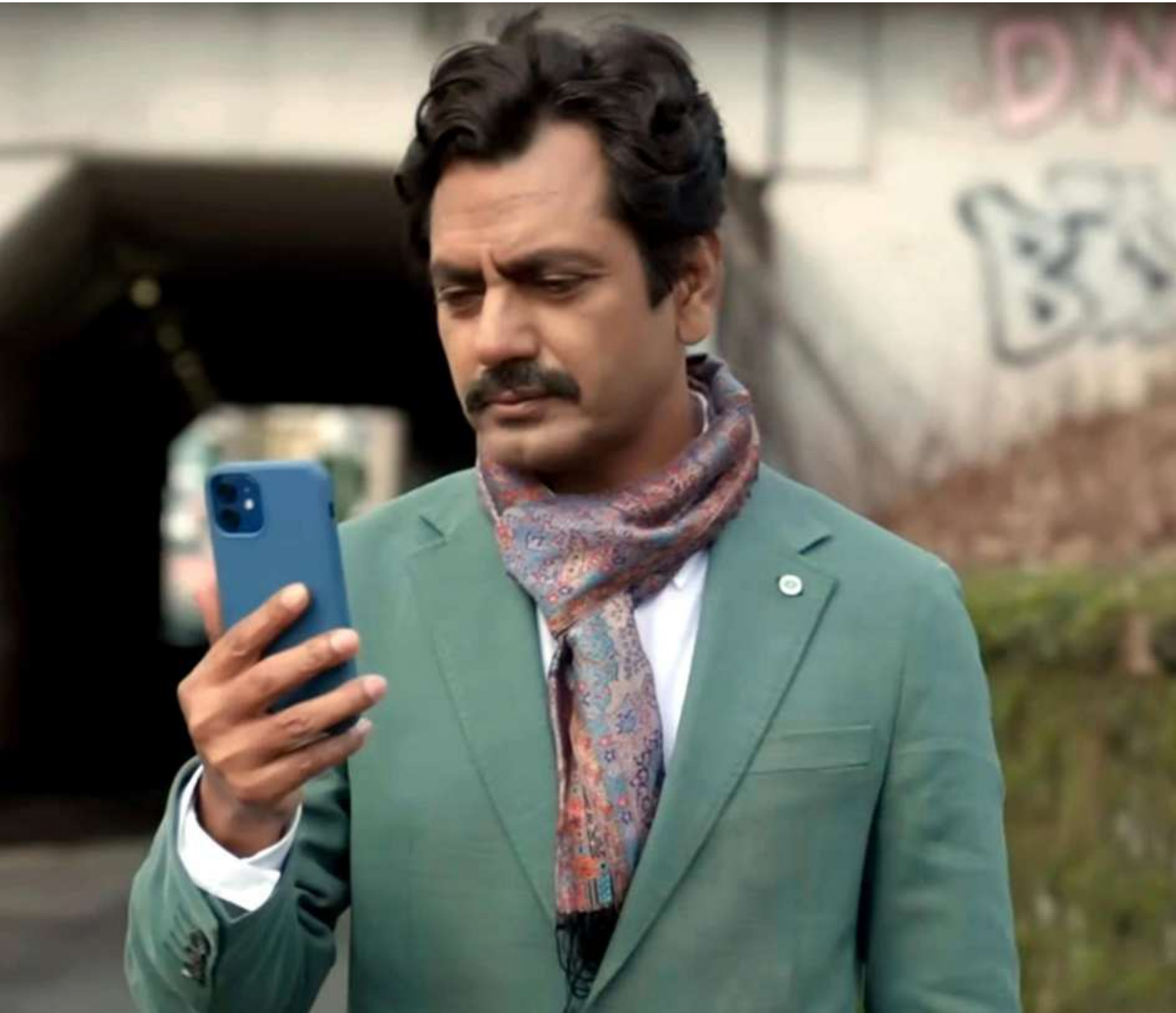
Dridam is currently running in theatres

Dridam

Director: Martin Joseph

Cast: Shane Nigam, Shobi Thilakan, Saniya Fathima, Dinesh Prabhakar, Krishna Prabha, Kottayam Ramesh, Nandan Unni

Storyline: A rookie cop takes charge at a relatively peaceful area, but things soon escalate after a murder and a robbery.



Exhausting indie loses charm

Main Actor Nahin Hoon breaks the rhythm of its minimalistic design with the voice of the filmmaker often getting in the way of letting the characters stay human

Hindi

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A man and a woman meet on a train in Europe. Losing themselves in conversation as they walk through picturesque, dreamy sites in Vienna, the two discover the delight of love. I was reminded of Richard Linklater’s wholesome talky romance *Before Sunrise* (1995) while watching Aditya Kripalani’s *Main Actor Nahin Hoon*, which largely follows two people walking in their respective cities as they connect over multiple video calls. The similarities and charms end there. *Main Actor Nahin Hoon* wants to be more than looking at its characters as objects of love. They drive with a purpose, leading to some heavy-handed conversations that break the rhythm of the film’s minimalistic design, with the director’s voice often getting in the way of letting them stay human.

The disjoint is felt mildly in the opening portions, where the screenplay begins to detach from the characters. Adnan (Nawazuddin Siddiqui), a retired banker, is introduced as he walks along with his daughter in Frankfurt. Their

Main Actor Nahin Hoon

Director: Aditya Kripalani

Cast: Nawazuddin Siddiqui, Chitrangada Satarupa, Naveen Kasturia

Synopsis: A melancholic banker in Frankfurt insists a struggling actor in Mumbai give her acting lessons to prepare for their combined audition



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conversation gives a glimpse into his background as an overachiever who has been living in melancholy of late. She asks him about hobbies, and he tells her he played smaller roles in his college plays. That’s when she suggests him to go to an audition for an international production. The details are a bit too convenient, and so is Adnan’s quick decision to go for the audition. He is distant from the get-go.

In comparison, Kripalani introduces Mouni (Chitrangada Satarupa), a frustrated, struggling actor in Mumbai, with an extended sequence. She is bitterly complaining about her life to her actor friends. Mouni is a trained actor who takes pride in quality work that satisfies her soul while balancing it with her saleswoman job.

There is little to like about Mouni and Kripalani caricatures her concerns. The one-dimensionality is apparent in how he imagines her living space, filled with film posters and a photo of the Globe Theatre in London, a dream place to perform for Mouni. Even the T-shirt Mouni wears carries a still of Madhabi Mukherjee from Satyajit Ray’s *Mahanagar*, where the lead character was a saleswoman too.

The references don’t really mean much apart from telling us about the filmmaker’s love for cinema and art, often coming across as a pretentious exercise. Like how Mouni suddenly goes on explaining her love for Tabu’s eyes in

Chandi Bar (2001) or her admiration for Jeanne Moreau in *Jim and Jules* (1962). There is little authenticity in these moments, and even the camaraderie between Mouni and Adnan feels more constructed than lived-in. Kripalani doesn’t let the characters breathe their own air.

Even the performances are incoherent as Chitrangada fuels the character with dramatic excess. There are multiple layers to the role that don’t quite come together to create an emotional backing. Even Siddiqui appears confused as he tries to figure out his acting chops as Adnan, often struggling to get the rhythm right in his delivery. He still manages to keep the film afloat with his reactions, especially in some emotionally charged scenes in the final act. Even here, Kripalani adds a reference to Van Gogh’s 1890 painting ‘At Eternity’s Gate’ as Adnan sits with his hands covering his face, with the painter’s small portrait seen in the background. It is an exhausting scene that overcomplicates the moment, making it seem more than what it actually is. The film, which began with a promise of simplicity, quickly turns into such moments of insipid emptiness. It says a lot, shows little, and means even less.

Main Actor Nahin Hoon is currently running in theatres

A romance drama that has its heart in the right place

Tamil

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When we meet 29-year-old Sathya, he is imploding with an identity crisis that most men his age go through. A graduate in Agriculture, he left his hometown, Salem, and found peace in a nine-to-five job in Chennai. He lives in a mansion with his friends, all of whom also seem to be stuck in motionless lives with no direction. Age is catching up, and he will soon turn 30.

“The difference between 28 and 29 is one year, but the difference between 29 and 30 is a lot,” he tells someone, before detailing the humiliation an unmarried bachelor undergoes when the clock runs out. Sathya’s world gets rocked when, as expected, a girl enters. Vijayalakshmi a.k.a Viji flies past him like a breeze on a sunny day, and Sathya’s definition of life, love and purpose finds a renewed meaning. They fall



in love, and “being a beautiful girl’s boyfriend” becomes Sathya’s identity. This is the setting of 29.

Segmented into 10 parts, Rathna’s breezy romance-drama is an ode to the old-school charm of early-2010s romance. It is primarily a story about how a couple ends up between the fantasy and reality of who they are. Though Rathna ends the film with mixed results in the ambitious

exploration of identity, it is the romance subplot that has a beating heart. Much of everything that transpires between Sathya (Vidhu) and Viji (Preethi Asrani) is told in a language that is sometimes sweet, sometimes over-the-top, and most of the time, in between.

There is a brilliant scene set in a motel room in which the writer in Rathna takes complete control.

There is tension between Sathya and Viji that remains unacknowledged. Beginning with a slight misunderstanding and ending in an argument, the scene captures everything going on in their minds. Rathna wields a clarity of thought that is evident in how, at any given point in the narrative, we understand both where the characters stand and why they choose to say or do almost anything. Speaking of which, Sathya’s ‘mind voice’ becomes a character by itself, called Seelay, which he expects Viji to somehow understand. This is a great example of one of those over-the-top ideas that somehow work in 29. So, what we end up seeing in Sathya is a man so confused that he hopes Viji understood parts of him that he struggles to bring out.

Where 29 loses steam is in the detour to a subplot featuring actor Mahendran. This is the part where Rathna addresses Sathya’s identity crisis, and while it seems all harmless on the surface, it can leave you scratching your head. Because one feels quite uncomfortable about the

meaning of self-discovery that the writer ascribes to. At one point, a dialogue by Sathya’s roommate and friend Mani makes one wonder if the film might pivot towards how matters of money, status, and class could wedge a gap between a couple. However, what we end up getting muddies it all and feels too misaligned with the reality the film

had been portraying until then. Similarly, not all the moments between Sathya and Viji feel organic. Sathya is not just Sathya of Viji. He is a Sathya to his friend Mani, a Sathya who lives in a small rented room in a terrace, a Sathya to his mother and father, and a Sathya to himself. These dimensions ensure that these characters appear lived-in. However, the star of the film is Preethi, whose Viji is easily one of the most effortlessly elegant depictions of a woman who learns to choose herself over others.

During our pre-release interview, director Rathna had stated some important requisites for a love story to work – good performers, confident producers who trust you, a catchy music album, a different script, and a unique treatment. In this regard, 29 is a film that ticks all the right boxes, and yet, there’s one key element that would determine whether the film works for you: the experience of outliving the fantasy of love.

29 is currently running in theatres



The Sheep Detectives

Director: Kyle Balda

Cast: Hugh Jackman, Nicholas Braun, Nicholas Galitzine, Molly Gordon, Julia Louis-Dreyfus, Bryan Cranston, Chris O’Dowd, Regina Hall, Patrick Stewart, Bella Ramsey, Brett Goldstein, Hong Chau, Emma Thompson

Storyline: When their dearly beloved shepherd is found dead, his flock swing into action to find whodunit

A sweet, smart fable

English

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At a time when quite a lot of content seems to lack grace, comes *The Sheep Detectives*, based on Leonie Swann’s 2005 novel, *Three Bags Full*, a film sure to bring a smile to your face, a lump in your throat, and restore your faith in humanity.

Simple and profound as it deals with death and slaughter for food, Kyle Balda’s *The Sheep Detectives* is gentle even as it uncovers the harshest truths. The fact that all this philosophy is wrapped in a crackerjack murder mystery is the icing on the cake.

In the little English town of Denbrook, George Hardy (Hugh Jackman) leads a solitary life, caring

for his sheep, all of whom he has named. There is smart Lily (Julia Louis-Dreyfus), quiet Sebastian (Bryan Cranston), Mopple (Chris O’Dowd), who remembers everything, pretty Cloud (Regina Hall), regal Sir Richfield (Patrick Stewart), curious Zora (Bella Ramsey), Wool-Eyes (Rhys Darby), so named because he has wool over his eyes, and the constantly head-butting twins Reggie and Ronnie (Brett Goldstein).

Every evening, George reads his favourite whodunits to his flock, secretly admitting to himself that no matter how clever sheep are, they cannot understand what he is reading to them. He is not further from the truth as of course sheep all listen carefully to his stories and are super annoyed when he stops reading just before the killer is unmasked, though Lily correctly guesses the killer.

When the sheep find George dead, they decide to find the murderer, especially since the crime seems to be following all the rules of a classic whodunit. There is the silly policeman, Tim Derry (Nicholas Braun), the Watson-reporter, Elliot Matthews (Nicholas Galitzine), and the visitor from afar, George’s daughter Rebecca (Molly Gordon).

The reading of the will by the family solicitor Lydia Harbottle (Emma

Thompson) reveals a clutch of suspects, including the innkeeper, Beth Pennock (Hong Chau), who was heard saying she wished she could kill George, Caleb (Tosin Cole), a shepherd who was heard arguing with George on the day before his death, Reverend Hillcoate (Kobna Holdbrook-Smith), who George left a considerable sum of money with and Ham (Conleth Hill), the butcher, who was suspicious of George’s vegetarianism.

However, Lily discovers life is not as neat as in a book. She makes mistakes and has to rethink certain beliefs but comes through in the end. There was a moment when casting almost pointed at the killer before the proper whodunit rules were applied.

The sheep are truly a marvel of CGI and the voice work is exemplary. While there are now many subversions of whodunits that are meta and fun, the ones that are most engaging are those that do not lose sight of the fact that they have a story to tell. And *The Sheep Detectives* is one of those wise, warm and witty whodunits. May their tribe increase.

The Sheep Detectives is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Babil Khan to make Malayalam film debut

Actor Babil Khan will be making his Malayalam film debut with *Gandhi Bazar Sunday Market*.

The film is directed by Babu Janardhanan and will also feature Aparna Balamurali, Deepak Parambol, Nikhil Nair, Johny Antony, Jagadish, Sudheer Karamana, Unni Raja, Athmiya, and Jayashankar in pivotal roles.

Gandhi Bazar Sunday Market will be shot by Fazil Nazer and edited by Sooraj ES. It will feature music by Nandhagopan V with lyrics by Rafeeq Ahammed. The film will go on floors soon.

Babil, the son of late actor Irrfan Khan, made his acting debut in 2022 with the Netflix psychological drama film *Qala*.



Akshay Kumar, Vidya Balan’s untitled comedy gets release date

Akshay Kumar and Vidya Balan will be seen next in filmmaker Anees Bazmee’s comedy-drama, that is currently untitled. The makers announced that the film will be released on December 4 this year.

The film recently wrapped a major Kerala schedule, with the makers expected to unveil a new still featuring Akshay in the coming days.

The film also stars Raashii Khanna, Vijay Raaz and Sudesh Lehri in pivotal roles. More details about the plot from the film are awaited.

Akshay was last seen in Priyadarshan’s horror-comedy, *Bhooth Bangla*.



Title look of Tovino Thomas-Nazriya Nazim starrer unveiled

The title look of the new Tovino Thomas - Nazriya Nazim starrer *Gracias El Clasico*, directed by Muhsin Parari, was launched on May 11 from Barcelona FC’s home ground, Camp Nou. The leading duo unveiled the title look of the film during the kickoff of the El Clasico match-up between Barcelona and Real Madrid.

The film is penned by Muhsin and Zakariya Mohammed, the director of the critically acclaimed *Sudani From Nigeria* and *Halal Love Story*.

Gracias El Clasico is produced by Sajin Ali, Abbas Thirunavaya, Sameer Thahir and Shyju Khalid. Sushin Shyam dons the cap of music composer for the film.



A button-mashing dud

Simon McQuoid’s sequel delivers the tournament carnage fans demanded, although endless lore dumps leave this arcade adaptation stuck in an eternal continue screen

English

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For a videogame franchise that built its global reputation on digitised heads exploding inside arcades, *Mortal Kombat II* spent over three decades surviving every possible fatality except cultural extinction. The series began in 1992 at Chicago-based developer Midway Games, where creators Ed Boon and John Tobias fused martial arts cinema, Hong Kong fantasy aesthetics, and shock-value gore into an instantly iconic fighting game. Simon McQuoid’s *Mortal Kombat II* follows his 2021 reboot, while still chasing the grubby cult energy of Paul W.S. Anderson’s pulpy 1995 adaptation with its techno soundtrack, latex-costume and cable-TV immortality.

Mortal Kombat II finally enters the arena by staging the franchise’s signature interdimensional death matches between Earthrealm, the human realm protected by lightning god Raiden, and Outworld, a militaristic empire ruled by the warlord Shao Kahn. The premise carries straightforward stakes because victory grants Shao Kahn dominion over Earth, although the screenplay keeps summoning jargon and loopholes that gradually turn this supposedly sacred combat structure into a series of forgettable side-quests.

McQuoid opens with a brutal prologue set in Edenia, a conquered fantasy kingdom where Shao Kahn murders King Jerrod before abducting the young Princess Kitana, whose eventual rebellion becomes the film’s spine. Adeline Rudolph does what she can with the flimsy material but the script frequently strands her inside exposition-heavy fantasy-speak. Armed with the character’s iconic steel fans, Kitana plots against the Outworld while trying to keep her allegiances undercover.

Karl Urban plays the iconic Johnny Cage, a washed-up Hollywood action star recruited into Earthrealm’s roster despite lacking supernatural powers. The

Mortal Kombat II

Director: Simon McQuoid

Cast: Karl Urban, Adeline Rudolph, Jessica McNamee, Josh Lawson, Ludi Lin, Tadanobu Asano, Lewis Tan Taslim, Tati Gabrielle

Storyline: Johnny Cage joins other fighters in the ultimate, no-holds-barred battle to defeat the dark rule of Shao Kahn

sunglasses-wearing narcissist originated inside the games as a parody of Jean-Claude Van Damme’s martial arts celebrity persona, although Urban plays him with an exhausted swagger, still clinging to convention-circuit relevance decades after his VHS glory days. The writing surrounds him with self-aware quips to *Big Trouble in Little China*, *The Lord of the Rings*, and fake 1990s action movies because it desperately wants Cage to become the audience’s ironic tour guide through this absurd mythology. Several jokes land, especially during Cage’s fight against the the snarling Tarkatan Baraka, although Urban’s performance gradually loses stamina once the runtime stretches past the hour mark and every wise-cracking one-liner starts sounding increasingly contrived.

The problem is that the film keeps treating its enormous roster like unlockable skins. Several performances suffer because the film’s fidelity to the game’s dense lore makes a majority of the non-fights feel like skippable cutscenes. Returning characters such as Sonya Blade, the military operative first introduced in the original 1992 game, and Jax, her cybernetically enhanced partner whose metal arms remain one of the series’ defining visual trademarks, are suspended in dispensing exposition about sacred relics and interdimensional politics that never develop beyond loading-screen mythology. Lewis Tan’s Cole Young, the original protagonist invented for the 2021 reboot because Warner Bros. seemingly distrusted the actual game characters to carry a mainstream blockbuster, spends much of the sequel trapped in generic hero duties before having his brain unceremoniously splattered across the floor. Even the fantastic Tadanobu Asano’s Raiden, the thunder god responsible for protecting Earthrealm through successive tournaments, sounds more exhausted by the script’s endless explanations and rules that appear to change whenever the screenplay corners itself, than having his literal life-force ooze out of his slit throat.

One of the film’s stronger set pieces is during a tournament-stage confrontation involving Liu Kang and his resurrected brother, Kung Lao. McQuoid stages the

fight inside an oversized combat arena, where it finally features some readable choreography instead of the choppy close-quarters editing that smothers much of the film. As the fire-bending Shaolin monk unleashes his trademark flaming bicycle kick while his brother’s razor-brimmed Douli hat spins menacingly around the arena, the sequence stuffs the frame with affectionate nods to longtime players, including classic audio cues, side-scrolling fight compositions, and visual recreations of famous fatalities; and for a few fleeting minutes the film finally achieves the button-smashing pleasures its source material mastered decades ago.

But the overall action produces mixed results despite finally delivering the tournament structure audiences expected five years ago. McQuoid frequently recreates the side-scrolling geometry of the arcade games, and several fatalities channel the series’ ultraviolent excesses through severed torsos, impaled skulls, and an array of weapons shredding the human body in delightful ways. Yet, the choreography often collapses beneath frantic rag-doll physics and spatial confusion, which drains momentum from most confrontations. Even the deaths themselves now carry little consequence because characters routinely respawn through Netherrealm loopholes.

That underlying cheapness eventually leaves its mark on the film’s textures. The polished soundstages of Outworld’s fantasy environments rarely feel lived-in and returning characters drift through scenes like NPCs waiting for selectable dialogue options. Though the film dutifully unloads every familiar catchphrase or gory callback, fan service iconography can hardly sustain excitement once it’s clear the movie has little else behind the joystick.

McQuoid delivers a sequel packed with blood, guts and glory, yet *Mortal Kombat II* keeps missing the clean finishing strike because it doesn’t seem to discover what made this universe so beloved beyond the simple pleasures of yelling “Finish Him!” while somebody explodes.

Mortal Kombat II is currently running in theatres